

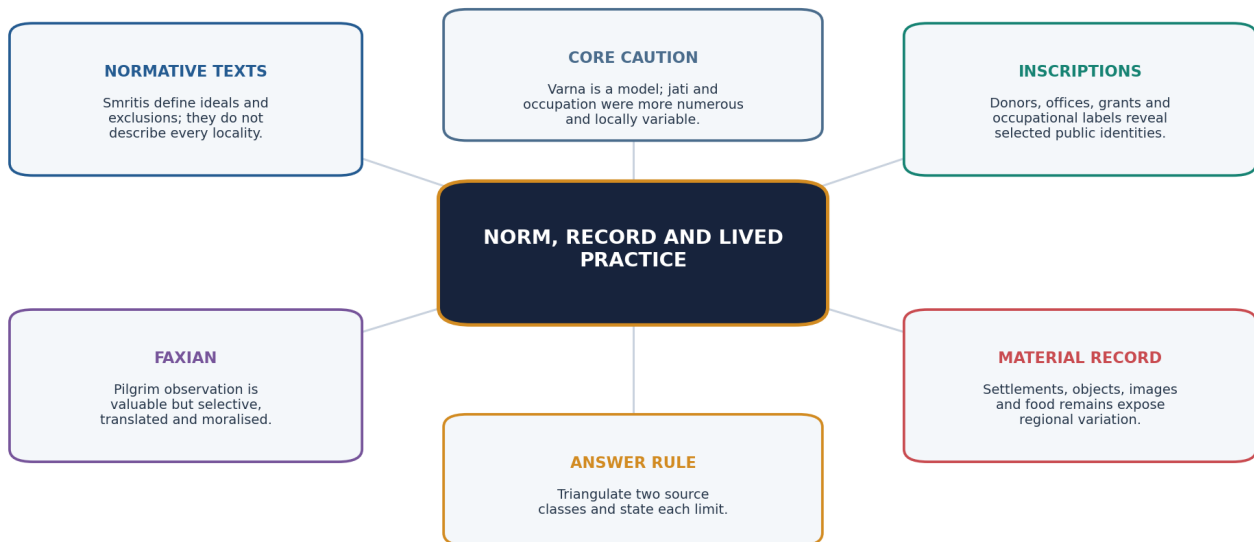
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Life & Culture in the Gupta Age - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Social hierarchy: evidence before assertion

Original deterministic UPSC study schematic



Do not turn a prescriptive verse or one traveller's sentence into a census of Gupta India.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

Life & Culture in the Gupta Age - Solved Practice Workbook 5

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION 5

Learning MCQ 01	5
Learning MCQ 02	5
Learning MCQ 03	5
Learning MCQ 04	5
Learning MCQ 05	5
Learning MCQ 06	6
Learning MCQ 07	6
Learning MCQ 08	6
Learning MCQ 09	6
Learning MCQ 10	6
Learning MCQ 11	7
Learning MCQ 12	7
Learning MCQ 13	7
Learning MCQ 14	7
Learning MCQ 15	7
Learning MCQ 16	8
Workbook MCQ 01	8
Workbook MCQ 02	8
Workbook MCQ 03	8
Workbook MCQ 04	8
Workbook MCQ 05	9
Workbook MCQ 06	9
Workbook MCQ 07	9
Workbook MCQ 08	9
Workbook MCQ 09	9
Workbook MCQ 10	10
Workbook MCQ 11	10

Workbook MCQ 12	10
Workbook MCQ 13	10
Workbook MCQ 14	10
Workbook MCQ 15	11
Workbook MCQ 16	11
Workbook MCQ 17	11
Workbook MCQ 18	11
Workbook MCQ 19	11
Workbook MCQ 20	12
Workbook MCQ 21	12
Workbook MCQ 22	12
Workbook MCQ 23	12
Workbook MCQ 24	12
Workbook MCQ 25	13
Workbook MCQ 26	13
Workbook MCQ 27	13
Workbook MCQ 28	13
Workbook MCQ 29	13
Workbook MCQ 30	14
Workbook MCQ 31	14
Workbook MCQ 32	14
Workbook MCQ 33	14
Workbook MCQ 34	14
Workbook MCQ 35	15
Workbook MCQ 36	15
Workbook MCQ 37	15
Workbook MCQ 38	15
Workbook MCQ 39	15
Workbook MCQ 40	16
Workbook MCQ 41	16
Workbook MCQ 42	16
Workbook MCQ 43	16

Workbook MCQ 44	16
Workbook MCQ 45	17
Workbook MCQ 46	17
Workbook MCQ 47	17
Workbook MCQ 48	17
Remedial 1 - Zero claim	17
Remedial 2 - Ajanta ownership	17
Remedial 3 - Women	18
Remedial 4 - Faxian	18
Remedial 5 - Golden Age	18
Remedial 6 - Temple style	18
Remedial 7 - Mitakshara	18
Remedial 8 - Sanskrit	18
PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE	18
Critically examine the description of the Gupta age as a Golden Age.	18
Discuss the relationship between social hierarchy and cultural production in the Gupta age.	19
Explain the contribution of Gupta-age mathematics, astronomy and metallurgy, with chronology cautions.	19
Verified PYQ 1 - Prelims 2020 Q29 (direct owner)	20
Adjacent PYQ 2 - Prelims 2020 Q36 (literature bridge)	20
Verified PYQ 3 - Prelims 2021 Q40 (routed demand)	21
Adjacent PYQ 4 - GS-I Mains 2022 Q12 (cross-owned)	21
Adjacent PYQ 5 - Prelims 2025 Q15 (cross-owned official key)	22
Original solved Mains - Explain how sources shape our understanding of daily life in the Gupta age.	22
Original solved Mains - Analyse the role of Sanskritisation in Gupta-age cultural integration.	22
Original solved Mains - Assess the relationship between religion, royal power and artistic production in the Gupta-Vakataka age.	23

Life & Culture in the Gupta Age - Solved Practice Workbook

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Learning MCQ 01

Which source pairing best tests a claim about Gupta social hierarchy?

- A. Smriti and inscription
- B. Only one coin type
- C. Only a modern textbook label
- D. Only a later legend

Answer: A. A prescriptive text establishes the norm; an inscription can test selected public practice.

Learning MCQ 02

Kulyavapa and dronavapa are best understood as

- A. marriage forms
- B. land-measure terms
- C. coin denominations
- D. guild offices

Answer: B. The official 2020 paper asks this exact distinction; they denote measurement of land.

Learning MCQ 03

Which statement is safest regarding Gupta-age women?

- A. Purdah was universal
- B. Women were absent from production
- C. Patriarchal norms coexisted with uneven agency
- D. All women enjoyed equal inheritance

Answer: C. The evidence supports a differentiated, source-aware conclusion.

Learning MCQ 04

Faxian's account should primarily be read as

- A. a Gupta revenue manual
- B. a complete census
- C. a neutral legal code
- D. a Buddhist pilgrim's situated account

Answer: D. His route and religious purpose shape both observation and silence.

Learning MCQ 05

The Mandasor silk-weaver inscriptions are especially useful for linking

- A. migration, corporate craft identity and patronage
- B. only village taxation
- C. only royal conquest
- D. only Buddhist doctrine

Answer: A. They connect mobility, guild identity, wealth and temple support.

Learning MCQ 06

Which is the correct chronology?

- A. Brahmagupta before Aryabhata
- B. Aryabhata before Varahamihira
- C. Vagbhata securely under Samudragupta
- D. Varahamihira before Kalidasa with certainty

Answer: B. Aryabhata is 499 CE; Varahamihira belongs to the sixth century.

Learning MCQ 07

The strongest caution about Aryabhata is that

- A. he wrote no mathematical work
- B. he lived in the Mauryan age
- C. place-value use is not the same as inventing zero
- D. he denied astronomy

Answer: C. Zero, place value and epigraphic notation have distinct histories.

Learning MCQ 08

Ajanta's major late phase is best described as

- A. Gupta imperial only
- B. Mauryan imperial
- C. Kushana court
- D. Vakataka-context within the Gupta-Vakataka age

Answer: D. This preserves the political and chronological caveat.

Learning MCQ 09

Sanskritisation in this period is best treated as

- A. adoption and local adaptation of prestige idioms
- B. one royal language law
- C. extinction of all Prakrits
- D. proof of universal literacy

Answer: A. It was negotiated and multilingual.

Learning MCQ 10

Sarnath Gupta sculpture is especially associated with

- A. blue-grey schist
- B. buff/cream sandstone and subtle robe treatment
- C. black basalt only
- D. bronze Nataraja

Answer: B. The material and modelling distinguish the Sarnath convention.

Learning MCQ 11

Which temple claim is safest?

- A. Bhitargaon is a rock-cut cave
- B. All Gupta temples had later Khajuraho scale
- C. Deogarh is an early sixth-century Vaishnava structural temple
- D. Sanchi Temple 17 is a Chola gopuram

Answer: C. Deogarh is a key early structural and iconographic example.

Learning MCQ 12

The Golden Age label is best evaluated as

- A. equally valid for every region and class
- B. a neutral census term
- C. false because no achievements occurred
- D. useful for classical production but socially uneven

Answer: D. This is the required graded verdict.

Learning MCQ 13

Which evidence most directly demonstrates plural patronage?

- A. Udayagiri's multiple religious presences and varied donors
- B. absence of all Buddhist sites
- C. one later court legend
- D. one modern nationalist slogan

Answer: A. Udayagiri combines Vaishnava royal imagery with Shaiva and Jaina presence.

Learning MCQ 14

Mitakshara and Dayabhaga should be treated as

- A. two Buddhist monasteries
- B. later Hindu-law commentarial schools
- C. two Gupta coin series
- D. two Gupta temple plans

Answer: B. They are later legal schools and must not be backdated.

Learning MCQ 15

Which claim about Kalidasa is most defensible?

- A. His date is fixed by a birth inscription
- B. Every navaratna legend is contemporary
- C. His works are secure but exact court association is debated
- D. He wrote the Aryabhatiya

Answer: C. The works are firmer evidence than the later biography.

Learning MCQ 16

A social-history answer should conclude with

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: D. The directive requires evaluation, not celebration.

Workbook MCQ 01

Which source pairing best tests a claim about Gupta social hierarchy?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: A. A prescriptive text establishes the norm; an inscription can test selected public practice.

Workbook MCQ 02

Kulyavapa and dronavapa are best understood as

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: B. The official 2020 paper asks this exact distinction; they denote measurement of land.

Workbook MCQ 03

Which statement is safest regarding Gupta-age women?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: C. The evidence supports a differentiated, source-aware conclusion.

Workbook MCQ 04

Faxian's account should primarily be read as

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: D. His route and religious purpose shape both observation and silence.

Workbook MCQ 05

The Mandasor silk-weaver inscriptions are especially useful for linking

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: A. They connect mobility, guild identity, wealth and temple support.

Workbook MCQ 06

Which is the correct chronology?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: B. Aryabhatiya is 499 CE; Varahamihira belongs to the sixth century.

Workbook MCQ 07

The strongest caution about Aryabhata is that

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: C. Zero, place value and epigraphic notation have distinct histories.

Workbook MCQ 08

Ajanta's major late phase is best described as

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: D. This preserves the political and chronological caveat.

Workbook MCQ 09

Sanskritisation in this period is best treated as

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: A. It was negotiated and multilingual.

Workbook MCQ 10

Sarnath Gupta sculpture is especially associated with

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: B. The material and modelling distinguish the Sarnath convention.

Workbook MCQ 11

Which temple claim is safest?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: C. Deogarh is a key early structural and iconographic example.

Workbook MCQ 12

The Golden Age label is best evaluated as

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: D. This is the required graded verdict.

Workbook MCQ 13

Which evidence most directly demonstrates plural patronage?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: A. Udayagiri combines Vaishnava royal imagery with Shaiva and Jaina presence.

Workbook MCQ 14

Mitakshara and Dayabhaga should be treated as

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: B. They are later legal schools and must not be backdated.

Workbook MCQ 15

Which claim about Kalidasa is most defensible?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: C. The works are firmer evidence than the later biography.

Workbook MCQ 16

A social-history answer should conclude with

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: D. The directive requires evaluation, not celebration.

Workbook MCQ 17

Which statement about the Mehrauli iron pillar is safest?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: A. Technical skill is secure; ruler identification and modern labels need caution.

Workbook MCQ 18

The Mandasor silk weavers most directly demonstrate

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: B. The inscriptions connect migration, occupation and religious endowment.

Workbook MCQ 19

Which statement best distinguishes stridhana?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: C. Recognition did not make the entire property regime equal.

Workbook MCQ 20

Which is NOT a safe Gupta-age claim?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: D. Brahmagupta is seventh-century and post-Gupta.

Workbook MCQ 21

Sanchi Temple 17 is useful as evidence for

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: A. It illustrates restrained early structural-temple form.

Workbook MCQ 22

Which pair is correctly matched?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: B. Sarnath is a major Gupta sculpture centre.

Workbook MCQ 23

The term 'Gupta-Vakataka age' is especially useful for

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: C. It preserves broad chronology and actual patronage context.

Workbook MCQ 24

Which conclusion is least defensible?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: D. The universal prosperity claim contradicts hierarchy and labour evidence.

Workbook MCQ 25

Which source is most directly prescriptive?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: A. Smritis set normative rules.

Workbook MCQ 26

A guild endowment primarily indicates

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: B. It shows historically specific financial and corporate capacity.

Workbook MCQ 27

Which statement about Kalidasa is safest?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: C. Works and later court legend must be separated.

Workbook MCQ 28

Which answer structure best fits 'critically examine Golden Age'?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: D. Critical examination needs criterion and balance.

Workbook MCQ 29

Which is a strong source-limit sentence?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: A. Genre-aware use is neither credulous nor dismissive.

Workbook MCQ 30

Aryabhata's eclipse explanation relied on

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: B. His astronomy explained eclipses through shadows.

Workbook MCQ 31

Which statement about language is correct?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: C. Court prestige did not eliminate other languages.

Workbook MCQ 32

Which is the proper ownership statement?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: D. Ownership must reflect actual syllabus and source function.

Workbook MCQ 33

The strongest use of Faxian is

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: A. His account is valuable when route and purpose are stated.

Workbook MCQ 34

Which is correctly paired?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: B. Amarakosha is traditionally attributed to Amarasimha.

Workbook MCQ 35

What most directly complicates a universal Golden Age?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: C. Social distribution is the decisive test.

Workbook MCQ 36

Which claim requires the strongest caveat?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: D. Nalanda developed over time.

Workbook MCQ 37

Varna should be used as

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: A. The model/practice distinction is fundamental.

Workbook MCQ 38

The principal value of Ajanta for daily life is

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: B. Visual evidence is rich but composed.

Workbook MCQ 39

Which statement about Puranas is safest?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: C. Their formation was cumulative.

Workbook MCQ 40

A good 20-mark conclusion should

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: D. The verdict should follow from the demonstrated criterion.

Workbook MCQ 41

Which named example best links artisans and patronage?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: A. Mandasor is the relevant Gupta-age corporate example.

Workbook MCQ 42

Deogarh is primarily associated here with

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: B. The Dashavatara temple anchors early sixth-century architecture.

Workbook MCQ 43

Which comparison is defensible?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: C. The comparison should avoid caricature while naming real differences.

Workbook MCQ 44

The phrase 'achievement for whom?' tests

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: D. It turns Golden Age into an evaluative question.

Workbook MCQ 45

Which route is correct for the 2025 Faxian question?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: A. This is the explicit anti-duplication boundary.

Workbook MCQ 46

Which statement about Buddhism is safest?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: B. Continuity coexisted with Puranic expansion.

Workbook MCQ 47

Which scientific figure is post-Gupta?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: C. Brahmagupta's 628 work is post-Gupta.

Workbook MCQ 48

Which is an invalid inference from Prabhavativgupta?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: D. An exceptional elite case cannot establish universal status.

Remedial 1 - Zero claim

Correct the statement: 'Aryabhata invented zero.'

Correction: Aryabhata's 499 CE procedures presuppose decimal place-value logic. The conceptual and epigraphic histories of zero are separate; Brahmagupta's explicit arithmetic rules belong to 628 CE.

Why this earns marks: the correction is dated, bounded and source-aware.

Remedial 2 - Ajanta ownership

Correct the statement: 'Ajanta is Gupta imperial painting.'

Correction: The principal late fifth-century phase is chiefly Vakataka-context production within the broader Gupta-Vakataka cultural age.

Why this earns marks: the correction is dated, bounded and source-aware.

Remedial 3 - Women

Correct the statement: 'Prabhavati Gupta proves women had equal status.'

Correction: She proves specific elite female authority. General status needs normative, inscriptional, labour and property evidence.

Why this earns marks: the correction is dated, bounded and source-aware.

Remedial 4 - Faxian

Correct the statement: 'Faxian gives an objective census.'

Correction: He provides situated pilgrim observation. Corroborate route-specific claims and do not infer from silence.

Why this earns marks: the correction is dated, bounded and source-aware.

Remedial 5 - Golden Age

Correct the statement: 'Social inequality means there was no cultural achievement.'

Correction: Critical evaluation preserves achievement while testing its social and spatial distribution.

Why this earns marks: the correction is dated, bounded and source-aware.

Remedial 6 - Temple style

Correct the statement: 'Gupta temples were mature Khajuraho-style Nagara temples.'

Correction: They represent earlier structural experiments; describe plan, material and superstructure before applying later style vocabulary.

Why this earns marks: the correction is dated, bounded and source-aware.

Remedial 7 - Mitakshara

Correct the statement: 'Mitakshara was a Gupta legal code.'

Correction: It is Vijñaneshwara's later commentary on Yajñavalkya Smṛiti; Dayabhaga is also later.

Why this earns marks: the correction is dated, bounded and source-aware.

Remedial 8 - Sanskrit

Correct the statement: 'Sanskrit replaced all other languages.'

Correction: It became a transregional prestige idiom while Prakrits and regional speech persisted.

Why this earns marks: the correction is dated, bounded and source-aware.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Critically examine the description of the Gupta age as a Golden Age.

Demand and thesis (20 marks): The label captures a real classical florescence but fails as a universal social judgement.

Evidence density target: 8-10 named units, each linked to significance.

Model answer:

[CLAIM] Literary and scientific production was exceptional. [EVIDENCE] Kalidasa's drama and kavya and Aryabhata's Aryabhatīya (499 CE). [SIGNIFICANCE] They created influential literary and mathematical-astronomical canons. [LIMIT] Both belong to specialist, largely elite knowledge worlds.

[CLAIM] Art and sacred architecture developed durable forms. [EVIDENCE] Sarnath Buddha images, Udayagiri Varaha, Sanchi Temple 17, Bhitargaon and Deogarh. [SIGNIFICANCE] Image, deity, patron and structural shrine became integrated. [LIMIT] Dating is not equally secure and later Nagara scale must not be projected backward.

[CLAIM] Cultural integration widened. [EVIDENCE] Sanskrit prashastis, Puranic redaction, Vaishnava-Shaiva-Shakta traditions, continuing Buddhist and Jain institutions. [SIGNIFICANCE] A transregional prestige idiom coexisted with sectarian plurality. [LIMIT] Sanskrit prominence did not erase multilingualism.

[CLAIM] The social base was unequal. [EVIDENCE] Faxian's Chandala passage, vishti, patriarchal Smriti norms and agrarian grants. [SIGNIFICANCE] Exclusion and labour obligations financed or accompanied elite visibility. [LIMIT] Sources are normative and regionally uneven, so inequality must be demonstrated without claiming a uniform condition.

[CLAIM] The label is spatially selective. [EVIDENCE] Ajanta's Vakataka setting and distinct peninsular trajectories. [SIGNIFICANCE] 'Gupta age' extends beyond direct Gupta rule. [LIMIT] It cannot replace regional histories.

Conclusion: The Gupta age was classical in enduring production, but golden only as a bounded historiographical description of selected achievements, not as a verdict on every region or social group.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, links each claim to named evidence, explains significance, states limitations and gives a graded verdict.

Discuss the relationship between social hierarchy and cultural production in the Gupta age.

Demand and thesis (15 marks): Cultural production drew resources and legitimacy from a hierarchical agrarian order while also creating integrative languages and institutions.

Evidence density target: 6-7 named units, each linked to significance.

Model answer:

[CLAIM] Agrarian surplus enabled patronage. [EVIDENCE] land-grant charters, kulyavapa/dronavapa measures and labour dues. [SIGNIFICANCE] Courts and religious beneficiaries could support texts, temples and specialists. [LIMIT] grant rights varied.

[CLAIM] Corporate wealth widened patronage. [EVIDENCE] Mandasor silk weavers and their Sun-temple support. [SIGNIFICANCE] Artisans and migrants were cultural agents, not passive subjects. [LIMIT] one inscription is not an all-India guild map.

[CLAIM] Hierarchy shaped access and representation. [EVIDENCE] Smriti norms, stridhana limits and Faxian's Chandala passage. [SIGNIFICANCE] education, property and public visibility were unequal. [LIMIT] normative and traveller evidence requires corroboration.

[CLAIM] Culture also integrated diverse regions. [EVIDENCE] Sanskrit inscription, Puranic traditions and shared iconographies. [SIGNIFICANCE] elites could communicate across polities. [LIMIT] Prakrits and local languages persisted.

Conclusion: Gupta culture was neither detached genius nor mere ideological cover: it was an unequal social process in which surplus, rank, mobility and plural patronage interacted.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, links each claim to named evidence, explains significance, states limitations and gives a graded verdict.

Explain the contribution of Gupta-age mathematics, astronomy and metallurgy, with chronology cautions.

Demand and thesis (10 marks): The secure contribution is substantial when Aryabhata and material metallurgy are separated from later attributions.

Evidence density target: 4-5 named units, each linked to significance.

Model answer:

[CLAIM] Aryabhata synthesised mathematics and astronomy. [EVIDENCE] Aryabhatiya, 499 CE, with pi approximation, trigonometric procedures, eclipse explanation and earth-rotation argument. [SIGNIFICANCE] It systematised computation and astronomical reasoning. [LIMIT] place-value use is not a claim that he invented zero.

[CLAIM] The tradition continued after the main Gupta phase. [EVIDENCE] Varahamihira in the sixth century and Brahmagupta's Brahmasphutasiddhanta in 628 CE. [SIGNIFICANCE] classical science was cumulative. [LIMIT] Brahmagupta is post-Gupta.

[CLAIM] Metallurgy achieved high technical control. [EVIDENCE] Mehrauli iron pillar. [SIGNIFICANCE] large wrought-iron manufacture and corrosion resistance. [LIMIT] the king Chandra identification is debated.

Conclusion: Precise chronology converts a triumphalist list into a defensible history of cumulative scientific practice.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, links each claim to named evidence, explains significance, states limitations and gives a graded verdict.

The separate workbook PDF contains the same PYQ, MCQ, remedial and original Mains material below.

Verified PYQ 1 - Prelims 2020 Q29 (direct owner)

With reference to the history of India, the terms "kulyavapa" and "dronavapa" denote: (a) measurement of land (b) coins of different monetary value (c) classification of urban land (d) religious rituals.

Status: INFERRED FROM AUTHORITATIVE SUBJECT KNOWLEDGE - OFFICIAL 2020 KEY NOT HELD LOCALLY.

Answer / route: A - measurement of land.

The terms occur in land-recording and agrarian-measure contexts. The distractors shift them into coinage, urban classification or ritual. Confidence: high.

Why this earns marks: ownership, answer-key status, evidence and limitation are explicit.

Demand decoding: Treat "Verified PYQ 1 - Prelims 2020 Q29 (direct owner)" as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "Verified PYQ 1 - Prelims 2020 Q29 (direct owner)", add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

Adjacent PYQ 2 - Prelims 2020 Q36 (literature bridge)

With reference to scholars/litterateurs of ancient India: 1. Panini is associated with Pushyamitra Shunga. 2. Amarasingha is associated with Harshavardhana. 3. Kalidasa is associated with Chandragupta II. Which statements are correct?

Status: INFERRED ANSWER - OFFICIAL 2020 KEY NOT HELD LOCALLY.

Answer / route: Statement 3 only; option C in the locally extracted Set A paper.

Panini predates Pushyamitra; Amarasingha is traditionally associated with the Gupta/Vikramaditya milieu rather than Harsha; the exam convention accepts Kalidasa-Chandragupta II while scholarship still cautions that exact court biography is debated. Confidence: high for exam elimination.

Why this earns marks: ownership, answer-key status, evidence and limitation are explicit.

Demand decoding: Treat "Verified PYQ 2 - Prelims 2020 Q36 (literature bridge)" as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "Verified PYQ 2 - Prelims 2020 Q36 (literature bridge)", add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

Verified PYQ 3 - Prelims 2021 Q40 (routed demand)

Locally audited demand: distinguish Mitakshara and Dayabhaga systems of property inheritance.

Status: ROUTED DEMAND; EXACT LOCAL PAPER/KEY NOT HELD. PROVISIONAL CONCEPT SOLUTION, NOT AN OFFICIAL KEY.

Answer / route: Core distinction: Mitakshara recognises a son's interest by birth in joint ancestral property; Dayabhaga generally opens the son's succession after the father's death.

Do not treat the schools as Gupta codes. Mitakshara is Vijnaneshwara's later commentary on Yajnavalkya Smriti; Dayabhaga is associated with Jimutavahana. The question is cross-temporal legal history.

Why this earns marks: ownership, answer-key status, evidence and limitation are explicit.

Demand decoding: Treat "Verified PYQ 3 - Prelims 2021 Q40 (routed demand)" as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "Verified PYQ 3 - Prelims 2021 Q40 (routed demand)", add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

Adjacent PYQ 4 - GS-I Mains 2022 Q12 (cross-owned)

Discuss the main contributions of Gupta period and Chola period to Indian heritage and culture. (15 marks, 250 words)

Status: VERIFIED ROUTING; Gupta culture supported here, Gupta polity Topic 20, Chola context Topic 27, form depth Indian Art and Culture.

Answer / route: Cross-owned model route.

Thesis: both periods created enduring cultural repertoires through different political economies. Gupta evidence: Kalidasa, Aryabhata, Sarnath/Mathura sculpture, early structural temples, Puranic plurality and Sanskrit prestige, qualified by regional patronage and social inequality. Chola evidence: Brihadishvara and other Great Living Chola Temples, bronze Nataraja, Tamil inscriptions, temple institutions and maritime-linked patronage, qualified by regional diversity. Comparison: Gupta contribution is especially canonical in Sanskrit literary-scientific and iconic vocabularies; Chola contribution is especially monumental, inscription-rich and temple-institutional. Why this earns marks: balanced periods, named evidence, comparison, qualification and direct discussion.

Why this earns marks: ownership, answer-key status, evidence and limitation are explicit.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "Verified PYQ 4 - GS-I Mains 2022 Q12 (cross-owned)", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Verified PYQ 4 - GS-I Mains 2022 Q12 (cross-owned)", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Adjacent PYQ 5 - Prelims 2025 Q15 (cross-owned official key)

Fa-hien (Faxian), the Chinese pilgrim, travelled to India during the reign of: Samudragupta / Chandragupta II / Kumaragupta I / Skandagupta.

Status: OFFICIAL 2025 SET A QUESTION AND KEY LOCALLY AVAILABLE; PRIMARY OWNER TOPIC 20.

Answer / route: B - Chandragupta II.

Faxian travelled c. 399-414 CE, overlapping Chandragupta II. Topic 21 uses the item to teach traveller-source limits.

Why this earns marks: ownership, answer-key status, evidence and limitation are explicit.

Original solved Mains - Explain how sources shape our understanding of daily life in the Gupta age.

Demand and thesis (10 marks): Daily life is recoverable only through triangulation because every source overrepresents a particular social world.

Evidence density target: 4-5 named units, each linked to significance.

Model answer:

[CLAIM] Normative texts reveal household and hierarchy ideals. [EVIDENCE] Smriti rules on guardianship and property. [SIGNIFICANCE] They disclose the elite social order. [LIMIT] They are prescriptive.

[CLAIM] Traveller observation adds selected practice. [EVIDENCE] Faxian's Chandala passage. [SIGNIFICANCE] It records exclusion. [LIMIT] It is route- and purpose-bound.

[CLAIM] Images and objects recover material and performative life. [EVIDENCE] Ajanta dress and gesture, terracotta and pottery. [SIGNIFICANCE] They widen the record beyond law. [LIMIT] artistic convention and survival bias remain.

Conclusion: The strongest reconstruction names the source, the social location and the confidence level for every detail.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, links each claim to named evidence, explains significance, states limitations and gives a graded verdict.

Original solved Mains - Analyse the role of Sanskritisation in Gupta-age cultural integration.

Demand and thesis (15 marks): Sanskritisation created a shared elite idiom but operated through regional negotiation rather than language replacement.

Evidence density target: 6-7 named units, each linked to significance.

Model answer:

[CLAIM] Sanskrit connected courts. [EVIDENCE] prashastis and kavya. [SIGNIFICANCE] rulers entered a transregional political-aesthetic field. [LIMIT] inscriptions do not prove popular speech.

[CLAIM] Puranic myths and sectarian icons widened cultural repertoires. [EVIDENCE] Udayagiri Varaha and Deogarh Vaishnava programme. [SIGNIFICANCE] belief, kingship and sacred space became mutually legible. [LIMIT] Shaiva, Shakta, Buddhist and Jain traditions continued.

[CLAIM] Local agents adapted the idiom. [EVIDENCE] regional courts, donors and workshops. [SIGNIFICANCE] integration did not erase locality. [LIMIT] Sanskritisation should not be described as frictionless.

[CLAIM] Multilingualism remained. [EVIDENCE] Prakrit and regional speech traditions. [SIGNIFICANCE] the process was layered. [LIMIT] literacy and language use cannot be quantified.

Conclusion: Sanskritisation was powerful because it was portable and adaptable, not because it created cultural uniformity.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, links each claim to named evidence, explains significance, states limitations and gives a graded verdict.

Original solved Mains - Assess the relationship between religion, royal power and artistic production in the Gupta-Vakataka age.

Demand and thesis (20 marks): Religion supplied symbols of sovereignty and fields of patronage, while artistic production depended on plural donors, workshops and regional courts.

Evidence density target: 8-10 named units, each linked to significance.

Model answer:

[CLAIM] Royal Vaishnavism translated power into cosmic order. [EVIDENCE] Udayagiri Varaha and Garuda symbolism. [SIGNIFICANCE] the king could be associated with protection and restoration. [LIMIT] iconography is not a literal political event.

[CLAIM] Structural temples stabilised deity-centred sacred space. [EVIDENCE] Sanchi 17, Deogarh and Bhitargaon. [SIGNIFICANCE] patronage joined image, ritual and architecture. [LIMIT] chronology and reconstruction differ by site.

[CLAIM] Plural traditions remained productive. [EVIDENCE] Shaiva and Jaina evidence at Udayagiri, Buddhist networks described by Faxian. [SIGNIFICANCE] royal preference did not eliminate multiple communities. [LIMIT] surviving monuments are uneven.

[CLAIM] Regional courts were decisive. [EVIDENCE] Vakataka-context Ajanta. [SIGNIFICANCE] the age's finest painting was not simply imperial Gupta output. [LIMIT] cave phases and patrons require care.

[CLAIM] Non-royal patrons mattered. [EVIDENCE] Mandasor silk weavers and lay donative traditions. [SIGNIFICANCE] merchants and artisans converted wealth into sacred culture. [LIMIT] corporate inscriptions are selective.

Conclusion: Gupta-Vakataka art was a negotiated field where sovereignty, devotion, corporate wealth and workshop skill converged without producing religious uniformity.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, links each claim to named evidence, explains significance, states limitations and gives a graded verdict.

These topic-specific register notes are deliberately last.

Demand decoding: Treat "Verified PYQ 5 - Prelims 2025 Q15 (cross-owned official key)" as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "Verified PYQ 5 - Prelims 2025 Q15 (cross-owned official key)", add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.